

in 51 airship raids on Britain, 557 people were killed and 1,358 injured; in 52 airplane attacks 857 were killed and 2,508 injured.

Hitting back

The damage inflicted by both airships and bombers was, in truth, a puny return for the investment of men and material. But its psychological impact was far-reaching. Shrill demands for a more effective defense of the civilian population caused a crisis in British policy on the air war. And the demand for revenge against the Germans gave fresh impetus to moves toward creating an Allied strategic bomber force.

Throughout the war, debate raged among both politicians and military commanders in the Allied countries as to the merits or demerits of bombing enemy cities and factories. The stalemate and heavy losses on the Western Front naturally encouraged speculation that bombers might be able to end the deadlock by breaking the enemy's will to fight or destroying his industrial capacity. It was certainly tempting to grasp at any alternative to yet another apparently futile infantry offensive. But those who saw the

GIANNI CAPRONI

GIANNI CAPRONI (1886–1957) was Italy's most prominent aircraft designer and manufacturer during World War I. After building his first aircraft in 1910, his efforts to win contracts from the Italian army were frustrated until he was befriended by the air-minded Colonel Giulio Douhet. By 1914 Caproni had already designed an innovative prototype monoplane fighter, the Ca 20, with a forward-firing gun mounted on top of the wing. Under the influence of Douhet, however, Caproni devoted himself primarily to the production of large bomber aircraft.

By the time Italy entered the war in 1915, Caproni three-engined biplane bombers (Ca 42s) were coming into service. By 1918 an estimated 70,000 workers were building Caproni biplanes and triplanes, not only in

Italy, but also under license in France and the United States.

Caproni joined Douhet in advocating a strategic air offensive that would have used thousands of heavy bombers to batter Germany into submission. This did not happen, but his arguments were influential, not least with American military aviation enthusiasts. After the war Caproni went on building civil and military aircraft.

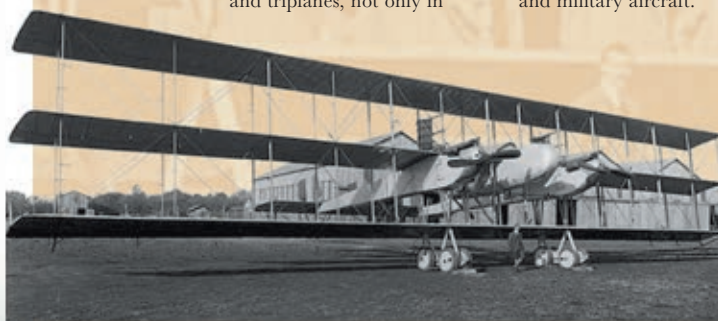


BOMBER MAN

Caproni designed a number of heavy bombers, including the Ca 33, which played a major role in the allied bombing campaign.

CAPRONI CA.42

The Ca 4 series of triplanes were used on Italian bombing missions against Austria. Despite being less common than the Caproni biplanes, they were more powerful.



trenches of the Western Front as the place where, inevitably, the war would eventually be won and lost, argued against any diversion of aerial resources away from direct support for the hard-pressed armies on the ground.

At first the debate was largely theoretical, since the Allies simply did not possess the equipment to carry out a strategic bombing campaign. French airmen made a brave attempt at bombing Germany from 1915 using slow, clumsy Voisin 8s, first by day and then by night, but their losses were high and the damage they inflicted negligible. Strangely, at first those Allied countries who generally had less-strong air forces possessed the most powerful bombers. Russia deployed Sikorsky's four-engined Il'ya Muromets (see pages 62–63) as bombers and reconnaissance

aircraft. Italy, which joined in the war on the Allied side in 1915, was at that time the only power to have an aircraft specifically designed for bombing, the Caproni Ca.1. Italy also had one of the most aggressive and influential advocates of strategic bombing in Colonel Giulio Douhet. His outspoken views and undisciplined behavior brought him in conflict with his superiors, and he spent part of the war in prison. But Italy nonetheless used Caproni bombers to attack the cities of its nearest enemy, Austria-Hungary.

Call for action

By 1918 there was a solid weight of opinion in the Allied countries calling for a bombing offensive against Germany, and frustration among political leaders at the military's failure to deliver it. In April 1918, Britain created the world's first independent air force, the Royal Air Force, to replace the army's Royal Flying Corps and the navy's Royal Naval Air Service. It was intended, among other things, to help give Britain more effective air defenses, and to promote a strategic air offensive against Germany. The Independent Force of bombers was set up in June to carry out this offensive. Meanwhile the French commander-in-chief, Marshal Henri Pétain, called for a fleet of heavy bombers to "paralyze

HEAVY BOMBERS

Entering service in the late summer of 1918, the Handley Page O/400 bomber was the key aircraft in the newly formed Independent Air Force. Large formations of O/400s – up to 40 bombers at a time – carried out night raids deep inside Germany. The aircraft's bombload could include a 1,650lb (750kg) "blockbuster" bomb.

